Low Energy High Precision Tests

Neutron EDM and Pion Decay

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What is a Neutron Electric Dipole Moment?

- The neutron is neutral, but a separation of positive and negative charge inside it would produce an electric dipole moment (EDM).
- An EDM is a vector $\vec{d}$ such that the interaction with an electric field is $H = -d\frac{\vec{S}\cdot\vec{E}}{|S|}$.
- In quantum mechanics, a non-zero EDM for a spin-$\frac{1}{2}$ particle requires both parity (P) and time-reversal (T) violation (and hence CP violation by the CPT theorem).
- The Standard Model predicts an extremely tiny nEDM ($\sim 10^{-31}\,e\,\mathrm{cm}$) mainly from the CKM phase.
- A measurable nEDM would be a clear sign of new physics.

Why is nEDM Important?

- It probes *CP* violation beyond the CKM mechanism.
- The current upper limit $|d_n| < 1.8 \times 10^{-26}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$ (90% C.L.) strongly constrains many extensions of the Standard Model.
- It is one of the most sensitive tests of the QCD θ term, the only remaining *CP*-violating parameter in the strong interactions.
- A discovery could help explain the matter–antimatter asymmetry of the Universe.

The QCD θ Term

In QCD, an extra CP-violating term is allowed by gauge invariance:

$$\mathcal{L}_\theta = -\frac{g_s^2}{16\pi^2}\,\theta\ \mathrm{Tr}\left(G_{\mu\nu}\tilde{G}^{\mu\nu}\right),$$

where $\tilde{G}^{\mu\nu} = \frac{1}{2}\epsilon^{\mu\nu\alpha\beta}G_{\alpha\beta}$.

- This term violates P and CP (but preserves C).
- Physical observables depend on the combination $\bar{\theta} = \theta + \arg\det(\mathcal{M}_q)$.
- The neutron EDM is the most sensitive probe of $\bar{\theta}$.

The Strong CP Problem

- The nEDM experimental bound implies $|\bar{\theta}| \lesssim 10^{-10}$.
- Why is this dimensionless parameter so tiny?
- In the Standard Model, $\bar{\theta}$ receives contributions from the bare θ and the phases of quark Yukawa couplings – both naturally $\mathcal{O}(1)$.
- This fine-tuning is the **strong CP problem**.
- Proposed solutions: (i) a massless quark (not favoured by phenomenology), (ii) the Peccei–Quinn mechanism (axion), (iii) spontaneous *CP* violation.

How to Compute $d_n(\theta)$: Effective Lagrangian

- After a chiral rotation, the θ term can be transformed into a CP-violating quark mass term:

$$\mathcal{L}_{CP} = -i m_* \bar{\theta}\, \bar{q}\gamma_5 q, \quad m_* = \frac{m_u m_d}{m_u + m_d}.$$

- This interaction induces a CP-odd pion–nucleon coupling $\bar{g}_{\pi NN}$ and a short-range contribution to the nucleon EDM.
- The leading contribution can be estimated using chiral perturbation theory (Crewther et al. 1979):

$$d_n \simeq \frac{e}{4\pi^2 f_\pi} g_{\pi NN} \bar{g}_{\pi NN} \ln \frac{\Lambda}{m_\pi}.$$

QCD Sum Rules Approach

Pospelov & Ritz (1999) used QCD sum rules for a more precise calculation:

- They considered the correlator of two nucleon currents in an external electromagnetic field and with the θ term.
- after
$$d_n(\theta) = (3.2 \pm 1.0) \times 10^{-16}\, \bar{\theta}\ e\,\mathrm{cm}.$$
- This result is close to the chiral logarithm estimate and yields the bound $|\bar{\theta}| < 3 \times 10^{-10}$.

The Peccei–Quinn Mechanism

- Introduce a new global $U(1)_{\mathrm{PQ}}$ symmetry that is spontaneously broken at a scale f_a.
- The associated Goldstone boson (axion) couples to $G\tilde{G}$ via

$$\mathcal{L}_a = \frac{a}{f_a}\frac{g_s^2}{16\pi^2}G\tilde{G}.$$

- The effecive θ parameter becomes $\bar{\theta} + a/f_a$.
- The axion potential $V(a) \sim m_\pi^2 f_\pi^2(1 - \cos(\bar{\theta} + a/f_a))$ dynamically relaxes the CP-violating combination to zero.
- The axion acquires a small mass $m_a \sim \frac{m_\pi f_\pi}{f_a}$.
- The original Peccei–Quinn model with $f_a \sim v_{\mathrm{EW}}$ was ruled out; invisible axion models (DFSZ, KSVZ) with $f_a \gg v_{\mathrm{EW}}$ are still viable.

Measuring the Neutron EDM: Principle

- The EDM is measured by observing the change in neutron spin precession frequency when an electric field is applied parallel or anti-parallel to a magnetic field.
- For a neutron with magnetic moment μ_n and EDM d_n, the spin precession frequency in parallel $\vec{E}$ and $\vec{B}$ is
$$\hbar\omega_{\pm} = 2|\mu_n B \pm d_n E|.$$
- Reversing the direction of $\vec{E}$ gives a frequency shift $\Delta\omega = 4d_n E/\hbar$.

Cryogenic Experiments

- Ultra-cold neutrons (UCNs) are used because they can be stored for long times (up to ~ 200 s), increasing sensitivity.
- Cryogenic temperatures (a few Kelvin) allow:
  - Longer storage of UCNs (reduced losses).
  - Reduction of thermal noise and magnetic field fluctuations.
  - Application of stronger electric fields without breakdown (up to 10kV/cm or more).
- Major cryogenic nEDM experiments:
  - PSI (Switzerland) – nEDM apparatus at the UCN source.
  - ILL (Grenoble) – historical experiments (e.g. Baker et al. 2006).
  - LANL (USA) – UCN source and EDM experiment.
  - TRIUMF (Canada) – planned experiment with advanced magnetometry.
- SQUIDs and co-magnetometers are used to monitor magnetic field drifts.

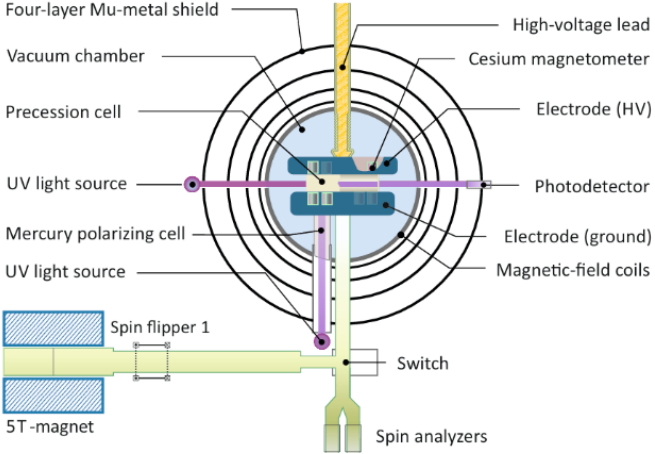
Current Limit

- The first neutron EDM searches began in the 1950s (Purcell, Ramsey).
- Over decades, the upper limit improved from $\sim 10^{-20}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$ to the current best:
- **PSI/ILL/RAL/Sussex collaboration (2006):** $d_n < 2.9 \times 10^{-26}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$ (90% C.L.).
- The most recent result from PSI (2020) gives $d_n < 1.8 \times 10^{-26}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
- This is the most precise measurement of any EDM and provides the strongest bound on the QCD θ parameter.

From Which Experiment Does the θ Bound Come?

- The limit $|\bar{\theta}| < 3 \times 10^{-10}$ is derived from the experimental bound on d_n using the theoretical relation $d_n(\theta) \approx 3.2 \times 10^{-16}\,\bar{\theta}\; e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
- This relation comes from the QCD sum rule calculation (Pospelov & Ritz) and is consistent with chiral perturbation theory.
- If a future experiment detects a non-zero d_n, it could be due to $\bar{\theta}$ or other CP sources; disentangling them requires multiple measurements (e.g., in different nuclei or using storage rings).

PSi


Four-layer Mu-metal shield
Vacuum chamber
Precession cell
UV light source
Mercury polarizing cell
UV light source
Spin flipper 1
5T -magnet
High-voltage lead
Cesium magnetometer
Electrode (HV)
Photodetector
Electrode (ground)
Magnetic-field coils
Switch
Spin analyzers

Systematic Errors and Challenges

$$\sigma(d_n) \approx \frac{\hbar}{2ETP^2\sqrt{N}}$$

- Magnetic field inhomogeneities: can mimic an EDM signal (false effect).
- Motional magnetic fields ($\vec{v} \times \vec{E}$) – the neutron experiences an effective magnetic field proportional to its velocity.
- Leakage currents and electrode charging.
- Geometric phase effects.
- Mitigation techniques:
  - Co-magnetometry (e.g., using ^{199}Hg atoms to measure the magnetic field simultaneously).
  - Electric field reversals.
  - Advanced magnetic shielding.

Future Sensitivity Goals

- Next-generation experiments aim to improve sensitivity by one to two orders of magnitude:
  - nEDM@PSI: goal $1 \times 10^{-27}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
  - nEDM@SNS (Oak Ridge): $2 - 3 \times 10^{-28}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
  - PanEDM at ILL: similar reach.
- Improved UCN sources (superthermal sources in superfluid helium, solid deuterium) will increase statistics.
- New techniques: storage rings for charged particles (proton, deuteron) can reach $10^{-29}\, e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
- A discovery would profoundly impact our understanding of *CP* violation and the origin of matter.

Summary

- The neutron EDM is a powerful probe of *CP* violation beyond the Standard Model.
- The current limit constrains the QCD θ parameter to $< 3 \times 10^{-10}$, illustrating the strong CP problem.
- Theoretical calculations using chiral perturbation theory and QCD sum rules provide the relation $d_n(\theta) \approx 2.4 \times 10^{-16}\,\bar{\theta}\; e\,\mathrm{cm}$.
- Cryogenic UCN experiments are pushing sensitivity further.
- The Peccei–Quinn mechanism offers an elegant solution via the axion.
- Future experiments may reveal a non-zero nEDM, opening a window to new physics.

References

- M. Pospelov and A. Ritz, "Theta vacua, QCD sum rules, and the neutron electric dipole moment," Nucl. Phys. B 573, 177 (2000) [arXiv:hep-ph/9908508].
- J. Engel, M. J. Ramsey-Musolf and U. van Kolck, "Electric dipole moments of nucleons, nuclei, and atoms: The standard model and beyond," Prog. Part. Nucl. Phys. 71, 21 (2013) [arXiv:1303.2371].
- C. Abel et al. (nEDM Collaboration), "Measurement of the Permanent Electric Dipole Moment of the Neutron," Phys. Rev. Lett. 124, 081803 (2020). doi:10.1103/PhysRevLett.124.081803[arXiv:1811.04012]

Pion Decay as a Precision Lab

Process: $\pi^+ \to \ell^+ \nu_\ell \quad (\ell = e, \mu)$

- **CKM Unitarity Connection:** CKM unitarity expresses the conservation of probability in quark flavor mixing, encoded in the unitary CKM matrix. In particular, the first-row relation $|V_{ud}|^2 + |V_{us}|^2 + |V_{ub}|^2 = 1$ provides a test of the Standard Model. Precision measurements determine V_{ud} allowing sensitive tests of this unitarity condition.
- **Helicity Suppression:** Helicity suppression in pion decay arises from the V–A structure of the weak interaction, which selects left-handed chiral states. In $\pi^+ \to l^+ \nu$, angular momentum conservation forces the charged lepton into the opposite helicity configuration, leading to a mismatch. This introduces a mass-dependent suppression in the amplitude, giving ($\Gamma \propto m_\ell^2$). Consequently, the electronic mode is strongly suppressed relative to the muonic one. .
- **Lepton Universality Test (R_π):** Lepton universality is the Standard Model principle that the weak interaction couples identically to all lepton flavors, independent of their masses. In pion decay, this implies that differences between $\pi^+ \to e^+ \nu$ and $\pi^+ \to \mu^+ \nu$ arise only from kinematics and helicity suppression. Precise measurements of the ratio ($R_{e/\mu}$) therefore provide a clean test of this universality.

Experimental Landscape: Low-Energy Precision Tests

1. **Exploiting Helicity Suppression:** Rare Decay Searches
   - **Observable:** Suppressed $\pi \to e\nu$ rate and e^+ spectrum (e.g., PIENU).
   - **Impact**: Confirms the $V - A$ structure of the weak interaction by verifying the m_ℓ^2 dependence. High-precision measurement of the suppression factor tests the predicted chiral structure of charged currents.
2. **Testing Lepton Universality:** $R_\pi = \Gamma(\pi \to e\nu)/\Gamma(\pi \to \mu\nu)$
   - **Experiments:** PIENU, PEN (completed), PIONEER (future).
   - **Impact**: Direct comparison of electronic and muonic decay rates at 10^{-4} precision. Verifies whether the weak interaction couples equally to electrons and muons.
3. **Testing CKM Unitarity:** Extracting $|V_{ud}|$
   - **Observable:** Pion beta decay ($\pi^+ \to \pi^0 e^+ \nu_e$) via PIBETA.
   - **Impact:** Provides measurement of $|V_{ud}|$. Used to test the unitarity relation $|V_{ud}|^2 + |V_{us}|^2 + |V_{ub}|^2 = 1$ with minimal theoretical uncertainty.

CKM Unitarity: What Does It Mean?

The CKM Matrix

The Cabibbo-Kobayashi-Maskawa (CKM) matrix describes the mixing between quark mass eigenstates and weak interaction eigenstates:

$$V_{\text{CKM}} = \begin{pmatrix} V_{ud} & V_{us} & V_{ub} \\ V_{cd} & V_{cs} & V_{cb} \\ V_{td} & V_{ts} & V_{tb} \end{pmatrix}$$

The Unitarity Condition

The Standard Model requires the CKM matrix to be **unitary**: $V^\dagger V = VV^\dagger = I$

This means all rows and columns form orthonormal vectors.

For the **first row**: $\boxed{|V_{ud}|^2 + |V_{us}|^2 + |V_{ub}|^2 = 1}$

Why Test Unitarity?

- Any deviation from 1 would be a **direct sign of new physics** beyond the Standard Model
- Could indicate: existence of a 4th generation of quarks, right-handed currents, or other exotic phenomena
- Provides one of the most precise tests of the Standard Model's consistency

Testing First-Row Unitarity: How We Get the Numbers

The Three Elements

- $|V_{ud}|$ (largest term):
  - From superallowed nuclear β decays
  - From pion beta decay ($\pi^+ \to \pi^0 e^+ \nu$)
- $|V_{us}|$: From kaon decays ($K \to \pi \ell \nu$)
- $|V_{ub}|$: From B meson decays (very small, $\sim 10^{-3}$)

Current Status (Global Fit)

$|V_{ud}|^2 + |V_{us}|^2 + |V_{ub}|^2 = 0.9985 \pm 0.0005$

$\Rightarrow \sim 2.8\sigma$ tension with unitarity $\to$ New physics? Better measurements needed?

Next-generation experiments (e.g., PIONEER) will improve precision by $10\times$.

Extracting V_{ud}: Why Pion Beta Decay?

The Current Standard: Nuclear β Decays

- $|V_{ud}|$ is most precisely extracted from superallowed $0^+ \to 0^+$ transitions.
- **The Issue:** These require complex nuclear structure corrections (δ_C, δ_{NS}, δ'_R), which introduce theoretical uncertainties.

The Clean Alternative: $\pi^+ \to \pi^0 e^+ \nu_e$

- It is a $0^- \to 0^-$ pure vector transition, relying on the same underlying physics.
- **The Advantage:** There are absolutely no nuclear structure effects to worry about.
- The hadronic matrix element is cleanly fixed by the Conserved Vector Current (CVC) hypothesis.

Motivation

Pion beta decay provides a theoretically clean, independent extraction of V_{ud} to test CKM unitarity.

Reference: J. C. Hardy and I. S. Towner, Phys. Rev. C 102, 045501 (2020), C. Y. Seng et al., Phys. Rev. Lett. 121, 241804 (2018)

Deriving the $\pi\beta$ Decay Rate: The Matrix Element

1. The Effective Hamiltonian

- The decay is mediated by the charged current weak interaction:

$$\mathcal{H}_{eff} = \frac{G_F}{\sqrt{2}} V_{ud} (\bar{u}\gamma^\mu(1-\gamma_5)d)(\bar{e}\gamma_\mu(1-\gamma_5)\nu_e)$$

2. Vanishing of the Axial Current

- The hadronic matrix element is $\langle \pi^0(p')|V^\mu - A^\mu|\pi^+(p)\rangle$.
- Since both pions are pseudoscalars ($J^P = 0^-$), the transition does not change parity.
- The axial-vector current A^μ changes parity, so its expectation value must vanish. Only the vector current V^μ contributes:

$$\mathcal{M} = \frac{G_F}{\sqrt{2}} V_{ud} \langle \pi^0|V^\mu|\pi^+\rangle \bar{u}_\nu \gamma_\mu (1-\gamma_5) v_e$$

Deriving the $\pi\beta$ Decay Rate: Form Factors & CVC

3. Form Factors and Dirac Contraction

- Lorentz covariance requires the matrix element to be a linear combination of the available momenta:

$$\langle \pi^0 | V^\mu | \pi^+ \rangle = f_+(q^2)(p+p')^\mu + f_-(q^2) q^\mu$$

  where $q^\mu = (p-p')^\mu = (p_e + p_\nu)^\mu$.

- Contracting q^μ with the leptonic current and applying the Dirac equation ($\not{p}_e v_e = -m_e v_e$ and $\bar{u}_\nu \not{p}_\nu \approx 0$) yields:

$$q^\mu \bar{u}_\nu \gamma_\mu (1-\gamma_5) v_e = -m_e \bar{u}_\nu (1+\gamma_5) v_e$$

- Because m_e is tiny, the $f_-(q^2)$ contribution is highly suppressed and vanishes.

4. CVC and the Master Formula

- The Conserved Vector Current (CVC) hypothesis relates the weak and EM currents, fixing $f_+(0) = \sqrt{2}$ via isospin algebra.

- Integrating $|\mathcal{M}|^2$ over the phase space ($I_{\pi\beta}$) yields:

$$\Gamma_{\pi\beta} = \frac{G_F^2 |V_{ud}|^2 M_\pi^5}{64\pi^3} |f_+(0)|^2 I_{\pi\beta} (1 + \Delta_{RC})$$

Radiative Corrections: The Bottleneck

Goal: Control Δ_{RC} for precise V_{ud}

Factorization

$$1 + \Delta_{\mathrm{RC}} = S_{\mathrm{EW}} \times (1 + \delta_{\mathrm{EM}}^{\pi\beta})$$

- S_{EW}: short-distance (high-energy)
- δ_{EM}: long-distance (low-energy)

Short-distance: S_{EW}

- Universal electroweak correction
- Dominated by $\ln(M_Z/M_\rho)$ running
- New dispersion-relation result (Seng et al.)

Shift $\sim 0.3\% \rightarrow$ directly impacts V_{ud}

Long-distance: δ_{EM}

- Non-perturbative QCD + QED effects
- Computed using χPT and lattice QCD

Dominant theoretical uncertainty

Impact on CKM Unitarity

CKM Test

$$|V_{ud}|^2 + |V_{us}|^2 + |V_{ub}|^2 = 1$$

Key Point

- $|V_{ud}|$ extracted from $\pi\beta$ depends on Δ_{RC}
- Shift in $S_{\mathrm{EW}} \to$ shift in $|V_{ud}|$

Current Situation

- Updated corrections $\to$ tension with unitarity
- Sum $\neq 1$ at ~ 2–3σ

$\to$ **Precision hinges on radiative corrections**

Experimental Challenge: $\pi\beta$ Decay

- **Strongly Suppressed Signal:** The small Q-value ($\sim$ 4 MeV) means the decay rate scales as Q^5.
- **Tiny Branching Ratio:** $\mathcal{B}_{\pi\beta} \sim 10^{-8}$, meaning only one in 10^8 pion decays produces the signal.
- **Overwhelming Backgrounds:** Ordinary pion decays such as $\pi^+ \to \mu^+\nu$ dominate at nearly 100%, while $\pi^+ \to e^+\nu$ occurs at the 10^{-4} level.
- **Detection Strategy:** Stop pions and identify events with a clean $\pi^0 \to \gamma\gamma$ signature in coincidence with a positron.
- **Systematic Control:** Measuring the ratio $\pi\beta/\pi e2$ further reduces systematic uncertainties.

Experimental Signature: $\pi^+ \to \pi^0 e^+ \nu$

- **Decay Chain:** Identified through $\pi^+ \to \pi^0 e^+ \nu$ with the subsequent decay $\pi^0 \to \gamma\gamma$.
- **Final State:** Consists of one positron, two photons in coincidence, and missing energy carried by the neutrino.
- **Reconstruction:** The two photons must reconstruct the neutral pion through $M_{\gamma\gamma} \approx M_{\pi^0}$.
- **Timing & Vertex:** All three visible particles must be in timing coincidence and originate from the pion stopping point.
- **Kinematic Constraints:** The total visible energy must be less than M_{π^+} to account for the undetected neutrino.

The PIBETA Experiment: Detector Design

Goal: Efficient detection of $\pi\beta$ events at high rate

The PIBETA experiment at PSI exploits an intense continuous pion beam ($\sim 10^6\ \pi^+/\mathrm{s}$) to achieve the statistics required for this rare decay. Pions are stopped in an active segmented scintillator target, which identifies the pion stop and measures the decay time, while also detecting the outgoing positron.

Surrounding the target, cylindrical multi-wire proportional chambers track the positron trajectory, providing vertex and timing information. The key detector element is a nearly 3π spherical calorimeter made of pure CsI crystals, optimized for high-resolution photon detection. This allows precise reconstruction of the $\pi^0 \to \gamma\gamma$ decay through energy, timing, and angular measurements.

Together, the combination of high beam intensity, precise tracking, and excellent photon detection enables efficient identification of the $\mathbf{e}^+ + \gamma\gamma$ signature of $\pi\beta$ decay.

Frlež, E. et al., "Design, commissioning and performance of the PIBETA detector at PSI," Nuclear Instruments and Methods in Physics Research Section A 526, 300–347 (2004), arXiv:hep-ex/0312017.

PIBETA Detector System

A schematic cross section of the PIBETA detector system. Symbols denote:

- BC–thin upstream beam counter,
- AC1,2–active beam collimators,
- AD–active degrader,
- AT–active target,
- MWPC1,2–thin cylindrical wire chambers,
- PV–thin 20-segment plastic scintillator barrel.

BC, AC1, AC2, AD and AT detectors are also made of plastic scintillator.

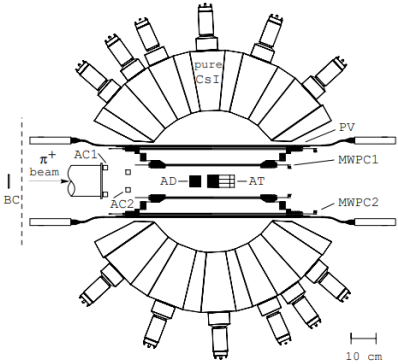


Figure 1. A schematic cross section of the PIBETA detector system. Symbols denote: BC–thin upstream beam counter, AC1,2–active beam collimators, AD–active degrader, AT–active target, MWPC1,2–thin cylindrical wire chambers, PV–thin 20-segment plastic scintillator barrel. BC, AC1, AC2, AD and AT detectors are also made of plastic scintillator.

The PIBETA Experiment: Results

Over several run periods, PIBETA accumulated $\sim 6 \times 10^{12}$ pion stops, yielding a final sample of **63,972 clean $\pi\beta$ events** after all selection cuts and background subtraction. The signal was identified through the $\pi^0 \to \gamma\gamma$ peak with a signal-to-background ratio exceeding $10:1$.

The measured branching ratio is

$$\mathcal{B}_{\pi\beta} = [1.036 \pm 0.004_{\text{stat}} \pm 0.004_{\text{syst}}] \times 10^{-8},$$

corresponding to a total precision of $\sim 0.6\%$, remarkable for such a rare decay.

Using the master formula, this gives

$$|V_{ud}| = 0.9728 \pm 0.0030,$$

in agreement with nuclear determinations, but with significantly larger uncertainty.

Takeaway: Demonstrates a clean experimental method, but higher precision is needed to compete with nuclear extractions.

Reference: Počanić et al. (PIBETA Collab.), Phys. Rev. Lett. 93, 181803 (2004) - Final results.

The PIONEER Experiment: Next-Generation Precision

Goal: Achieve $\sim 0.01\%$ precision in $\pi\beta$ decay

PIONEER is designed to improve the precision of $\pi\beta$ decay by an order of magnitude, motivated by recent shifts in radiative corrections and the resulting tension in CKM unitarity. Reaching this level of precision would allow a clean and competitive determination of V_{ud}, independent of nuclear structure uncertainties.

The key innovation is a high-granularity silicon active target (ATAR) based on LGAD technology, providing precise spatial and timing information for all particles in the decay. This enables full event reconstruction with excellent vertex resolution and particle identification, significantly reducing the dominant systematics present in PIBETA.

Combined with a next-generation electromagnetic calorimeter optimized for photon detection, PIONEER aims to collect $\sim 10^7$ $\pi\beta$ events, reaching a total precision at the 10^{-4} level.

Takeaway: PIONEER will transform $\pi\beta$ decay into a precision probe of V_{ud} and a decisive test of CKM unitarity.

Reference: Altmannshofer et al. (PIONEER Collab.), arXiv:2203.01981 - PIONEER physics case.

Lepton Universality in the Standard Model

Principle: Equal coupling of leptons to the weak interaction

In the Standard Model, all leptons couple identically to the W boson, independent of their flavor:

$$g_e = g_\mu = g_\tau$$

This implies that any difference in decay rates involving e, μ, or τ arises purely from kinematics and well-understood corrections, not from the underlying interaction strength.

Pion decays provide a clean test through the ratio

$$R_\pi = \frac{\Gamma(\pi^+ \to e^+\nu)}{\Gamma(\pi^+ \to \mu^+\nu)},$$

in which common factors such as G_F, f_π, and V_{ud} cancel.

Key point: R_π directly probes the coupling ratio $(g_e/g_\mu)^2$ in a theoretically clean way.

Reference: Bryman et al., Annu. Rev. Nucl. Part. Sci. 61, 331 (2011) - Review of pion decay tests of universality.

Helicity Suppression in $\pi^+ \to \ell^+ \nu_\ell$

Key idea: Angular momentum vs. $V-A$ interaction

In the pion rest frame, the decay $\pi^+ \to \ell^+ \nu_\ell$ produces two back-to-back leptons with total angular momentum $J = 0$. This requires the final state to be in a spin-singlet configuration, implying that the lepton and neutrino must have the **same helicity**.

However, the weak interaction has a $V-A$ structure and couples only to left-chiral fields. In the relativistic limit, this means the neutrino is left-handed ($h_\nu = -1/2$), while the positron is produced right-handed ($h_{\ell^+} = +1/2$).

Conflict: Angular momentum requires $h_{\ell^+} = h_\nu$, while the weak interaction enforces opposite helicities. For massless leptons, these conditions cannot be satisfied simultaneously, and the decay would be forbidden.

Chirality vs. Helicity

- The weak interaction couples to chirality, not helicity.
- For massive leptons, a left-chiral state contains a small component of the "wrong" helicity proportional to m_l/E_l.
- Consequently, the decay amplitude and rate are directly proportional to the lepton mass: $\mathcal{M} \propto m_l \Rightarrow \Gamma \propto m_l^2$.

The Master Formula

- Squaring the amplitude and integrating over phase space yields the Standard Model ratio:

$$R_\pi = \left(\frac{m_e}{m_\mu}\right)^2 \left(\frac{m_\pi^2 - m_e^2}{m_\pi^2 - m_\mu^2}\right)^2 (1 + \delta_{rad})$$

- The $(m_e/m_\mu)^2$ penalty completely overpowers the phase space advantage, strongly suppressing the electronic mode.

Confirming Lepton Universality

- The Standard Model prediction is ruthlessly suppressed to a highly precise $R_\pi^{SM} = (1.2352 \pm 0.0001) \times 10^{-4}$.
- Experimental measurements agree at the 0.1% level ($R_\pi^{exp} \approx 1.23 \times 10^{-4}$).
- This agreement confirms lepton universality and the $V - A$ structure of the weak interaction with high precision.

Reference: Cirigliano and Rosell, Phys. Rev. Lett. 99, 231801 (2007)]

Experimental Challenge: π_{e2} Signal vs Background

Goal: Isolate $\pi^+ \to e^+\nu$ from dominant muon decays

The π_{e2} decay is rare ($\sim 1.2 \times 10^{-4}$) and produces a monoenergetic positron at $E_e \approx 69.8$ MeV. In contrast, almost all pions decay via $\pi^+ \to \mu^+\nu \to e^+\nu\bar{\nu}$, yielding a continuous Michel spectrum extending up to 52.8 MeV. Although the signal lies above this endpoint, finite detector resolution generates a low-energy tail that can overlap with the background, requiring precise control of the energy response.

Experimentally, pions are stopped in an active target and the signal is identified using the combination of a sharp energy peak and timing information, which separates prompt pion decays ($\tau_\pi \sim 26$ ns) from delayed muon decays ($\tau_\mu \sim 2.2$ μs). Measuring the ratio

$$R_\pi = \frac{\pi \to e\nu}{\pi \to \mu\nu}$$

further cancels common systematic uncertainties.

Takeaway: A 10^{-4} signal must be extracted from a ~ 1 background with $\sim 0.1\%$ precision.

Reference: Bryman et al., Annu. Rev. Nucl. Part. Sci. 61, 331 (2011)

The PEN Experiment (PSI)

Goal: High-precision measurement of R_π with large statistics

The PEN experiment at PSI exploits an intense continuous pion beam ($\sim 2.5 \times 10^5$ stops/s) to collect millions of rare π_{e2} events, targeting $\sim 0.05\%$ precision. The strategy is based on **large acceptance and precise event reconstruction**, using a nearly 3π pure CsI calorimeter (inherited from PIBETA) for accurate energy and timing measurements of positrons.

Upstream tracking with a mini time projection chamber identifies incoming beam particles and ensures clean pion stopping, while downstream wire chambers track outgoing positrons and provide kinematic consistency checks. Together with an active target, this enables full event reconstruction and strong suppression of $\pi \to \mu \to e$ backgrounds.

Takeaway: High beam intensity + large acceptance + precision tracking $\Rightarrow > 10^7$ events and sub-0.1% tests of lepton universality.

References: Glaser et al. (PEN Collaboration), arXiv:1812.00782 [nucl-ex]; Počanić et al., Nucl. Instrum. Meth. A 523, 278 (2004) (PIBETA detector).

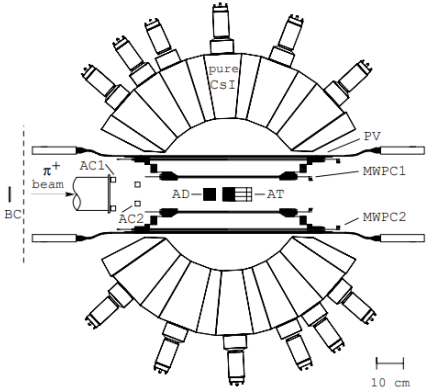


Figure: PEN Detector Design

PEN Collaboration, arXiv:1701.05254 (2017)

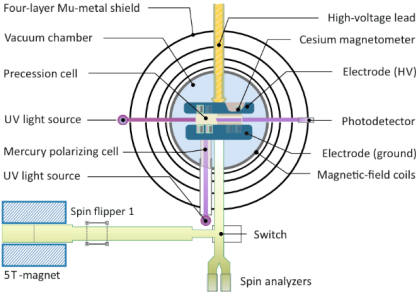


Figure: Separation of $\pi \to e\nu$ signal and $\pi \to \mu \to e$ background using a likelihood discriminator.

The PEN Experiment

In the PEN experiment, pions stop in an active target and decay either directly via π_{e2} or through the dominant chain $\pi \to \mu \to e$. The crucial difference is in the time structure: π_{e2} produces a prompt positron (two pulses), while $\pi \to \mu \to e$ produces an additional delayed muon signal (three pulses over μs timescales).

Instead of integrating signals, PEN uses fast waveform digitizers (2 GS/s) to record the full time evolution of the detector signal. This allows individual pulses from the pion, muon, and positron to be resolved directly in the data.

By identifying or vetoing the intermediate muon pulse, experiments can cleanly separate π_{e2} events from the overwhelming $\pi \to \mu \to e$ background with high efficiency.

Takeaway: Recording the full waveform enables data-driven background rejection and reduces systematics to the $< 0.1\%$ level.

References: Palladino et al. (PEN Collab.), Nucl. Instrum. Meth. A 671, 44 (2012); Počanić et al., AIP Conf. Proc. 1182, 705 (2009).

The PEN Experiment

Key challenge: Signal leaking into background

The π_{e2} signal produces a sharp positron peak at 69.8 MeV, but the calorimeter response develops a low-energy tail due to shower leakage, photonuclear effects, and energy loss in inactive material. As a result, a fraction of signal events is reconstructed below the Michel endpoint (52.8 MeV), where they become indistinguishable from the dominant $\pi \to \mu \to e$ background.

Since these events cannot be separated event-by-event, the tail fraction must be determined with high precision. Even a small uncertainty directly biases the measured ratio R_π, making this the dominant systematic limitation.

PEN addresses this using dedicated calibration runs with monoenergetic positron beams to measure the detector response and constrain simulations. This enables control of the tail contribution at the $\sim 0.1\%$ level.

Takeaway: Precise modeling of the calorimeter tail is the main bottleneck in achieving sub-0.1% precision.

Reference: Glaser et al. (PEN Collaboration), arXiv:1812.00782

The PIENU Experiment (TRIUMF)

The PIENU experiment at TRIUMF adopts a complementary strategy to PEN, using a lower-intensity pion beam and focusing on precise energy measurement rather than large acceptance. Instead of a 3π calorimeter, PIENU employs a single large NaI(Tl) crystal placed downstream of the target, selecting forward-going positrons and achieving superior energy resolution.

The high light yield of NaI produces a sharper positron peak at 69.8 MeV, significantly reducing the low-energy tail that contaminates the Michel background. An active surrounding "skirt" detector captures escaping shower energy, further improving energy reconstruction and controlling leakage effects.

Timing and simple tracking are used to separate prompt π_{e2} decays from delayed $\pi \to \mu \to e$ events, while the reduced rate minimizes pile-up and simplifies analysis.

Takeaway: PIENU achieves competitive precision through excellent energy resolution and tail control, providing an independent approach with different systematics from PEN.

Reference: Aguilar-Arevalo et al. (PIENU Collaboration), Nucl. Instrum. Meth. A 791, 38 (2015) - PIENU detector design.

PIENU Results: Precision Test of R_π

Statistics: PIENU collected $\sim 2.2 \times 10^7$ π_{e2} events from $\sim 10^{12}$ pion stops (2009–2012), making the measurement systematics-limited.

Method: Signal extracted using timing (prompt vs delayed), energy spectrum fits (peak + tail vs Michel background), and acceptance corrections validated with control samples.

Result:

$$R_\pi^{\text{exp}} = (1.2344 \pm 0.0030) \times 10^{-4} \quad (0.24\%)$$

Dominant systematics: energy scale (0.10%), tail modeling (0.08%), timing/acceptance ($\sim$ 0.05% each).

Comparison with SM:

$$\frac{R_\pi^{\text{exp}}}{R_\pi^{\text{SM}}} = 0.9994 \pm 0.0024$$

Extracted:

$$\frac{g_e}{g_\mu} = 0.9997 \pm 0.0012$$

Takeaway: Agreement at 0.2% confirms lepton universality at the 10^{-3} level, making π_{e2} one of the most precise low-energy tests of the Standard Model.

Reference: Aguilar-Arevalo et al. (PIENU Collaboration), Phys. Rev. Lett. 115, 071801 (2015) - Final PIENU R_π results.